



English H Review Guide

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Range: (Grammar, Unknown Americans, Vocab, Lexis)

Note: (Review Guide) are UNOFFICIAL sources of reference and do NOT include or hint at questions in the actual exam!

Types of Relative Clauses

Relative clause:

- A clause that gives more information about a noun
- Begins with who, which, that, where, whose, etc.

Non-essential clause (Nonrestrictive clause)

- A clause that gives more information also use comma
- Example: 'My brother, who lives in California, is visiting us next week'

Essential clause (restrictive clause):

- A clause that doesn't give extra information
- No comma
- Example: The car that is parked outside belongs to my neighbour.

Parallel structure:

- > definition: using the same grammatical form for similar elements in a sentence.
 - > fixing parallel structure: Ensure each list or series use the same form.
- Example: 'She likes reading, writing, and running.'

(Not sure if this will be tested but you still need to know it):

Journalistic voice: - inform audience about facts, events, issues

- generally objective and neutral
- concise and straightforward, sentences are often short.
- follows inverted pyramid structure—> Important info comes first.
- heavily relies on quotes, statistics

Narrative voice: - aim to tell story

- follows a narrative arc
- subjective, reflective —> allowing emotional depth
- focuses on character's thoughts, feelings, motivations
 - more varied and flexible style—> sentences can be longer, more complex, often employing literary devices.
- uses rich, evocative description to create atmosphere and evoke emotion.

Book of unknown Americans

- When Written: 2009-2013
 - When Published: 2014
 - Genre: Literary fiction
 - Setting: Newark, Delaware, U.S.A.
 - Climax: Believing his daughter Maribel is in danger, Arturo sets out to confront the boy he believes is responsible and he is shot and killed along the way.
- Antagonist: Garrett Mille

Plot summary:

The novel follows *Arturo and Alma Rivera*, who move from Mexico to Newark, Delaware with their teenage daughter *Maribel* in hopes of healing her after a traumatic brain injury. Maribel attends a special school while her parents struggle to adapt: Arturo works long hours at a mushroom farm, and Alma faces deep homesickness. Their lives intertwine with neighbors *Celia* and *Rafael Toro*, and their son *Mayor*, who becomes close to Maribel despite her condition. As Mayor and Maribel grow closer, they are targeted by a school bully, *Garrett Miller*, who eventually assaults Maribel. Alma tries to shield her daughter, but the incident and other tensions escalate. Arturo loses his job, and the family's American dream begins to unravel. Meanwhile, Mayor defies his parents, steals

a car, and takes Maribel out to experience her first snowfall, causing panic when she doesn't return home.

Arturo, trying to find Maribel, confronts Garrett's family and is fatally shot by Garrett's father. The tragedy devastates the community, and Alma and Maribel prepare to return to Mexico. The neighbors raise money to help them bring Arturo's body back home. As Alma and Maribel leave, Alma realizes that Maribel, despite her injury, has always been herself, and they drive on, carrying their loss and hope into the future.

Important characters:

1. Alma Rivera – The Protective and Guilt-Ridden Mother

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Role: Protagonist, matriarch of the Rivera family.

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Themes: Isolation vs. community, maternal love, guilt, fear, adaptation.

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Character Arc: Alma begins the story consumed by guilt over her daughter's accident, which propels her to seek a better life in the U.S. Though she finds community at the Redwood Apartments and builds deep friendships, especially with Celia, Alma remains emotionally isolated. Her overprotectiveness and silence about Garrett's assault on Maribel—rooted in shame and fear—ultimately leads to tragic consequences. Yet, Alma also learns to reframe her understanding of Maribel, accepting her daughter not as “lost” but transformed.

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Symbolism: Alma symbolizes the sacrifices and quiet resilience of immigrant mothers, as well as the inner conflict between personal guilt and societal survival.

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2. Arturo Rivera – The Selfless Father and Martyr

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Role: Breadwinner of the Rivera family.

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Themes: Sacrifice, family, the American Dream, dignity.

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- Character Arc:** Arturo is hardworking and selfless, laboring in grim conditions to provide for Maribel's education. His enduring optimism and humor provide emotional warmth to the family. However, his tragic death following a misunderstanding with Garrett's family positions him as a **martyr**—a man who dies trying to protect what little hope he had built.
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Symbolism: Arturo represents both the dream and the futility of the American immigrant experience—the idea that hard work doesn't always yield justice or security in a broken system.

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3. **Maribel Rivera** – The Symbol of Lost and Reclaimed Identity

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- Role:** Catalyst of the plot, daughter of Alma and Arturo.
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Themes: Disability, trauma, identity, love, coming of age.

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Character Arc: Once vibrant and rebellious, Maribel becomes quiet and confused after her injury. While many treat her as incapable, her relationship with Mayor reveals her inner self and potential for healing. By the end, she reclaims aspects of her identity, and Alma realizes she never truly lost her.

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Symbolism: Maribel embodies both the fragility and resilience of personhood. She challenges societal definitions of value and capability.

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4. **Mayor Toro** – The Sensitive Adolescent in Search of Purpose

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- Role:** Alma's narrator counterpart and Maribel's friend/love interest.
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Themes: Adolescence, masculinity, love, rebellion, perception.

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- Character Arc:** Mayor begins as a boy trapped by his father's unrealistic expectations and his own self-doubt. His love for Maribel becomes a vehicle for asserting his identity, but also exposes his immaturity and naivety. His idealized love leads to tension and tragedy, but also growth.
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- Symbolism:** Mayor represents the second-generation immigrant youth, caught between two cultures and expectations, struggling to find his own path.
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5. **Celia Toro** – The Bridge Between Cultures

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- Role:** Mayor's mother, Alma's best friend.
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- Themes:** Friendship, gender roles, nostalgia, endurance.
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- Character Arc:** Celia is nurturing and pragmatic, supporting her family and friends with wisdom and kindness. She balances emotional intelligence with practicality, especially in her friendship with Alma and in handling her husband Rafael's temperament. She also symbolizes the longing for home—one that no longer exists.
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- Symbolism:** Celia is the emotional bedrock of the community and an anchor to the immigrant experience of lost roots and found kinship.
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6. **Rafael "Rafa" Toro** – The Disillusioned Patriarch

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- Role:** Mayor's father.
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- Themes:** Masculinity, authority, trauma, generational conflict.
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Character Arc: Rafa's harshness comes from a desire to see his family thrive, shaped by his traumatic past. His rigidity and obsession with success create conflict, especially with Mayor. He embodies the difficulty many first-generation immigrants face when reconciling past hardship with a new culture.

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Symbolism: Rafa symbolizes both the trauma of war and migration, and the dangers of unyielding patriarchal expectations.

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7. **Garrett Miller** – The Embodiment of Threat and Privilege

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Role: Local bully and antagonist.

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Themes: Racism, privilege, danger, repression.

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Character Arc: Garrett is mostly static—he represents the looming threat to immigrant safety. His harassment of Maribel and subsequent confrontation with Arturo result in tragedy. Yet, glimpses of his own troubled family life suggest a cycle of abuse and neglect.

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Symbolism: Garrett personifies unchecked privilege, toxic masculinity, and the dangers of silence and complicity.

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8. **Quisqueya Solis** – The Masked Survivor

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Role: Gossip and narrator of her own story.

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Themes: Shame, survival, identity.

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Character Arc: Outwardly flamboyant and dramatic, Quisqueya hides a history of abuse and trauma. Her need for control and social status masks a painful past.

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Symbolism: She represents the complexities of identity formation and the need to rewrite one's narrative to survive.

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Supporting Characters as Community Voices:

Each minor character at Redwood Apartments adds texture to the immigrant mosaic:

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Benny Quinto – A former seminarian turned smuggler and prayer leader; symbolizes contradiction and redemption.

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Gustavo Milhojas – A janitor with a tragic past and enduring hope; reflects perseverance and generational sacrifice.

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Adolfo “Fito” Angelino – The kind landlord; symbolizes the evolution of the American Dream.

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Nelia Zafón & José Mercado – Artists thwarted by systems of oppression; embody the theme of unrealized potential.

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Micho Alvarez – A photographer and activist; voices political resistance and cultural pride.

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Key themes:

1. Immigration and the American Dream

- **Explored through:** Nearly every character, particularly Alma and Arturo Rivera.

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Many characters came to the U.S. seeking opportunity, safety, or a better future for their children. Yet the reality they face—poor working conditions, poverty, and social alienation—shows the complexity and sometimes the futility of the "American Dream."

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Arturo's tragic death underscores how even hardworking, optimistic immigrants can be thwarted by systemic barriers and prejudice.

2. Isolation vs. Community

- **Explored through:** Alma Rivera, Celia Toro, the Redwood Apartments residents.

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The immigrants are isolated by language, culture, and trauma. Alma feels especially alone due to guilt and fear.

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However, the Redwood Apartments become a small, vibrant community where immigrants support one another in ways that are emotionally and materially vital.

3. Love and Relationships

- **Explored through:** Mayor and Maribel's budding romance; Alma and Arturo's marriage; the Toro family dynamics.

Love is shown in its many forms: romantic, parental, platonic. The novel questions what it means to love someone who is changed by trauma, as Alma does with Maribel.

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Mayor's love for Maribel becomes both redemptive and problematic—raising ethical questions about consent, care, and agency.

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4. Trauma and Recovery

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Explored through: Maribel's brain injury; Quisqueya's childhood abuse; immigrants' stories of war, loss, and displacement.

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The characters carry emotional and physical scars. Maribel's recovery is slow and nonlinear, and each immigrant's trauma affects how they integrate into American society.

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The novel suggests that healing is possible, but it requires patience, understanding, and community.

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5. Family and Sacrifice

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Explored through: Alma and Arturo's sacrifices for Maribel; Rafa's demands of his sons; Celia's longing for her family.

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Immigrant parents often sacrifice everything to give their children better lives, even at great personal cost.

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Alma's guilt and resolve to help Maribel drive the family's migration, and Arturo ultimately pays with his life.

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6. Identity and Belonging

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Explored through: Mayor's adolescent insecurities; Rafa's rejection of his "gringo" label; Celia's nostalgia for Panamá.

Lexis:

Voice - The distinct personality or style of an author as expressed in their writing - The author's voice in the novel captures the struggles of adolescence with humor and poignancy.

Auto theory - A concept that emphasizes self reflection and personal experience in understanding art and literature - In her essay, she applied auto theory to explore how her own upbringing influenced her interpretation of the text.

Assimilation - The process by which individuals or groups adopt the cultural norms of another group, often losing their original identity – The story explores the challenges of assimilation faced by immigrant families in a new country.

Cultural monolith - The idea that a culture is uniform and unchanging, ignoring its diversity and complexity - The film critiques the concept of a cultural monolith by showcasing the varied experiences within a single community.

Passing (for white) - The act of a person of non-white ethnicity being perceived as white, often to gain social advantages - The protagonist grapples with the implications of passing for white in a society that values whiteness.

Point of view - The perspective from which a story is told, influencing how

events and characters are perceived - The shift in point of view in the novel allows readers to understand the motivations of both the hero and the antagonist.

Double consciousness - A concept describing the internal conflict experienced by marginalized groups in a dominant culture, particularly in understanding one's identity - The character's sense of double consciousness highlights the struggle between their cultural heritage and societal expectations.

Latino - A term used to describe people of Latin American origin or descent, encompassing a diverse range of cultures and identities - The anthology features stories from various Latino authors, each offering unique perspectives on identity and belonging.

Vocab

Surge - A sudden and powerful increase or rise

- I lay there listening to the soft chorus of Maribel's and Arturo's long, even breaths. In and out. In and out. The **surge** of possibility. The tug of doubt. Had we done the right thing, coming here?

Ambivalent - Experiencing mixed feelings; often feelings of both liking and disliking - When he looked **ambivalent**, I lied and said, "I've been practicing with my dad at home. Even he thinks I'm getting better."

Bewildered - confused - It was a story about how Yu Li came to the United States from China with his parents. He went to school one day and some of the kids taunted him and some of them were kind. But Yu Li didn't know

English, so he was **bewildered**.

Meagerness - a small amount; not enough - But when Arturo didn't say anything, I felt acutely the **meagerness** of it, the insufficiency. We wanted more. We wanted what we had come here for.

Compliant - Willing to follow rules, standards, or requests - She resisted, she was confused, and then, suddenly, something would snap back into place and she was **compliant**, agreeable.

Imploring - Begging or pleading earnestly and desperately - And sometimes I went to the small church we had found, St. Thomas More Oratory, with its water-stained drop ceiling and its folding chairs in place of pews, and sat alone in the empty sanctuary, reciting the same prayers over and over, **imploring** God to listen.

Indignation - Strong displeasure or anger aroused by something seen as unfair - The boy said something in English, something unintelligible to me, but I could hear the **indignation** in his tone, and without thinking, I turned and spat in his face.

Conception - process of conceiving or forming an idea; the beginning or origin of something - Arturo usually frowned when she did those things—they didn't fit the Mexican **conception** of what girls could and

should do—but I loved that about Maribel.

Reproach - Expressing disapproval - “I’m sorry,” I murmured, the combined weight of horror and **reproach** pressing against my chest.

Rehabilitation - The process of restoring someone to health - After weeks of **rehabilitation**, after working with a psychologist and a speech language pathologist and the doctor, all they could tell us was things like: She struggles with finding the right words sometimes, and that will likely persist.

Machismo - A strong or exaggerated sense of masculinity, often characterized by dominance - In the time that he and my mom had been gone, I’d talked myself into the idea that maybe my dad would be proud of me—just a little bit—when he found out I’d gotten into a fight. Maybe it proved I had a little bit of **machismo** in me after all.

Indestructible - Impossible to destroy or damage - We believed we were special. We believed we were **indestructible**. But after the accident, under the gathering clouds of fate, something changed.

Careened -to fall into someone or something; out of control- He **careened** around us and, as he passed by, yelled out his open window, “Learn how to f**king drive!”

Lusted - a strong desire for someone or something - I had a feeling she’d been one of the popular girls, the one all

the guys **lusted** over.

Revelry - noisy festivities; playful - And then, in the middle of the revelry, we heard a knock at the door.

Legitimate - real or true - A guard examined the driver's papers, which were **legitimate**. The guard did not know we were in the back of the van.

Exonerated -to clear of blame - My dad glanced at my mom and for one delirious second I thought I was on the hook, that somehow I'd **exonerated** myself, and that we could all just go back to business as usual.

Virtuous -full of integrity; showing high moral standards - He believed a man should work hard with his hands, that toil and sweat were evidence of a **virtuous** life.

Advocating - publicly recommend or support - Now I work with a group in Wilmington that's **advocating** for legislation reform for immigrants.

Misguided - showing bad judgement or reasoning - What did it matter, my instinct to protect him, my **misguided** idea that somehow by keeping all of this from him, I could prove that I was capable, I could prove that I could take care of our daughter even though I had failed her so terribly before?

Condolence - an expression or sympathy, especially during a time of

death - She apologized over and over, and though at first I mistook her apologies for **condolences**, I realized soon enough that she believed she had a role in what had happened—or maybe that Mayor did

Impetuous - **done quickly without thought** - Not exactly the girl she used to be before the accident, which was the girl I thought I had been searching for, but my Maribel, brave and **impetuous** and kind.

Assaulted - **Physically attacked** - We don't deal with teenage relationships here. Unless he **assaulted** her in some way, or unless he made some kind of verbal threat, there's nothing we can do.

Erupt- **To burst forth suddenly and violently** - My hip throbbed. Coach blew his whistle and jogged in to untangle us. The girls **erupted** in laughter.

Discarded -**to get rid of or throw away death** - Later, when he stopped again and pointed to a **discarded** kitchen table, and later again at a mattress propped up like a sliding board against someone's mailbox, we understood what to do and loaded them into the truck.

Barren - **empty or lacking in vegetation, often land that is unable to support plant life.** - It was snowing when we arrived—Enrique kept complaining that the snow was going to mess up his beloved Adidas sneakers—and everything was so colorless and

barren that it looked like the moon.

Constrict - To tighten, squeeze, or flatten - He walked closer, and I felt the world **constrict**, my heart pulsing against my ribs. When we were only an arm's length apart, he stopped.

Excruciating - Extremely intense or painful - It was a lovely thought, but hearing Arturo's optimism bubble to the surface, hearing the rawness of it, was **excruciating**.

Console -to comfort - At the hospital, Officer Mora, the same officer I had spoken with at the station months earlier, tried to **console** me.

Indisputable - not able to dispute or argue against. - "She's getting better," I said, as if by repeating it enough, I could somehow make it part of the public record, an **indisputable** fact.

(Quizlet for vocab for practice):

[Click here](#)

If it doesn't work then use this link: <https://quizlet.com/cn/1052411741/final-h-level-vocab-flash-cards/?i=3eosgh&x=1qqt>